

2018 Audi Q5 technology, drive review: Understated elegance

The new, facelifted Audi Q5 has been through a diet, while keeping every bit of its goodness alive. Is that enough to make it stand out from the pack?

Souvik Das | souvik@digit.in

BUILD QUALITY, DESIGN AND AESTHETICS

The 2018 Audi Q5 gets a new single-piece grille that's more compact and neater than before. Refinements to this car's design include the narrower headlamps, and a near Q7-esque form.

The C-pillar has a sharp bend inward, and the tailgate has a distinct two-step texture. The rear profile looks the most appealing and adds road presence to a rather muted design. The rear scuff plate-mounted exhaust pipes look quite nice. The car now looks more mature, and the 65 kilo weight loss over its older generation actually shows.

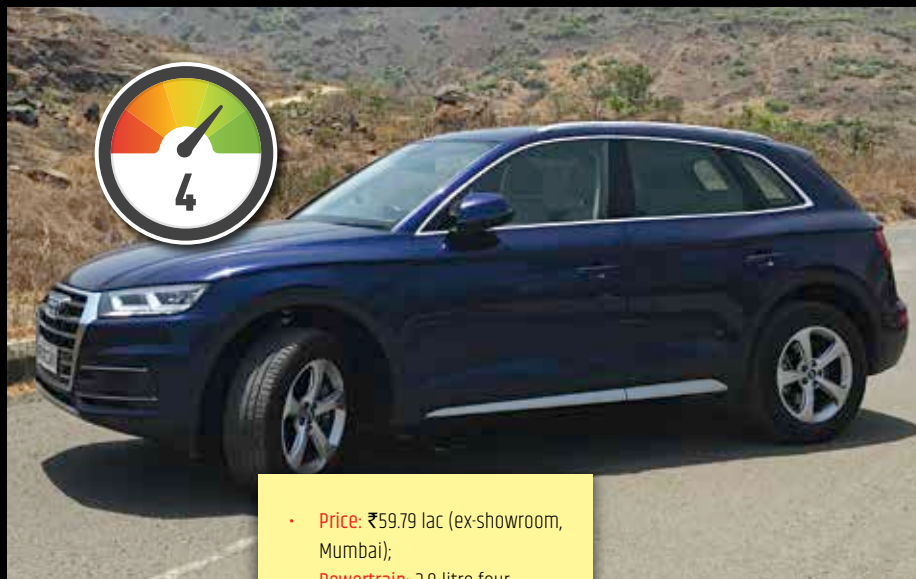
Inside, the dashboard, door panels and central column comprise black leather, a running strip of wood and beige soft touch plastic elements.

The panoramic glass roof and the beige leather make the cabin feel roomy. The rear seats can be adjusted slightly for pitch and recline, and are quite comfortable.

VIRTUAL COCKPIT AND MMI INFOTAINMENT

The Audi Virtual Cockpit is a 12.3-inch digital instrument cluster, which has two views - standard and progressive. Both include multifunctioning digital sections inside them, with the left dial including the tripmeter, and the right including quick graphic navigation prompts.

The 8.3-inch MMI infotainment display has a minimal floating design that doesn't distract on the road. From this interface, the full range of functions you can access



include drive modes, customisable shortcuts, ambient lighting, driver assistance systems, tyre pressure and oil level indicators, audio personalisation, media and telephony, navigation, and Apple CarPlay and Android Auto.

OTHER ELECTRONICS

The jet thruster-like gear selector is an impressive element here. The touchpad is precise and responsive, you get eight programmable capacitive shortcuts, and a clickable touchpad.

You get three-zone air conditioning in the Q5, and the audio setup is fairly decent, but isn't the best in class. The MMI system can be internet-enabled to receive live traffic updates, for which it comes with a SIM card slot along with two SD card ports. There is 10GB storage, and a wireless charging pad as well.

DRIVE AND RIDE QUALITY

The Audi Q5 has steady calmness to its ride. On highways, it effectively negates

- **Price:** ₹59.79 lac (ex-showroom, Mumbai);
- **Powertrain:** 2.0-litre four-cylinder diesel, 190bhp/400Nm, 7-speed S-Tronic automatic gearbox, Quattro permanent all-wheel drive;
- **Fuel economy:** 17.01kmpl (ARAI certified);
- **Pros:** Smart styling, Top notch interior quality, Virtual cockpit looks great, MMI interface is incredibly smooth, Solid engine and smooth gearbox, Adaptive suspension makes ride smoother;
- **Cons:** Lacks oomph, Steering wheel is too light, Lacks a bit of excitement, Audio system could have been better;

wind and road noise, and the seats are beautifully bolstered. The rear row of seats can be brought forward to accommodate more luggage, or even get some additional recline.

The 7-speed S-Tronic dual-clutch gearbox is very smooth. There are adaptive dampers that can tune the suspension depending on where you're driving. The Audi Q5 runs on

18-inch alloys, and they hold well in terms of the grip. Even though this is an SUV with raised ground clearance, the car sits squat on the road and feels planted at all points.

FINAL VERDICT

There's not a single thing that is 'not good' about this car. It is built solidly, looks smarter and faster than before, packs in all the technology that you'd use everyday, has a solid powertrain and offers good comfort. It lacks flair, but none of that gets in the way of making it a commendable mid-size luxury SUV. **A**